

THE BRIEF

AUDIENCE

Reach / NCAD leadership & the development team

FRAMING

Operating doctrine for grants & partnerships

THE REFRAME

Funding is a power law — chase the few, not the many

THE ASK

Concentrate scarce team time at the top of capacity × alignment

KEY SIGNALS

\$592B
U.S. charitable giving, 2024 • Giving USA

\$84T
Great wealth transfer through 2045 • Cerulli

~426K
UHNW individuals (>\$30M) • Altrata

120K+
U.S. foundations — few move most dollars

THREADS

- Power Law
- Mega-Foundations
- UHNWI / New Money
- Form 990s
- Prospect Research

The engine: a funder corpus + agents (see Agent Workflow Maxxing) make studying many funders' footprints tractable for a small team. Figures pending verification.

Don't spray small applications. Concentrate where the money actually is.

Grant funding follows a power law: a small number of mega-foundations move most of the dollars, and a fast-growing population of ultra-wealthy individuals hold enormous discretionary capacity. The method is to reverse-engineer the few funders who can write the biggest, most-aligned checks — and design the ask to hit their sweet spot at the largest plausible size.

- **The 990 tells you what they funded; the call tells you why.** Public footprint reveals the history; a conversation reveals the thesis behind the checks.
- **Start from what they can give, then shape the ask.** Reverse the usual flow — design to the largest amount that still fits their pattern, not a default small request.
- **Effort follows dollars.** A handful of precisely-aligned asks to the biggest, best-fit funders out-raises a hundred generic applications to the long tail.

01 A POWER LAW

Available funding is **not** evenly distributed. Of 120,000+ U.S. foundations, a few hundred of the largest move a hugely disproportionate share of grant dollars (Gates largest; Mellon ~\$302M, RWJ ~\$293M dwarf the median). A power law, not a bell curve.

03 THE METHOD

- **Study** the public footprint — 990s, Candid, press, principals' statements.
- **Get the intro call** — the highest-leverage step; learn the thesis.
- **Pattern-recognize** the recurring shape they keep paying for.
- **Align** the ask to their sweet spot, sized up.

CHASE THE FEW

the top of that list. **A few precise asks beat a hundred generic ones** — and new money is more discretionary, faster, and looking for a cause to call its own. Reverse the flow: start from what a funder can give, then shape the program to match.

02 TWO CONCENTRATED POOLS

- **Mega-foundations** — predictable, RFP-driven, deep capacity.
- **New-money UHNWIs** — more **discretionary**, faster decisions, identity-driven; less predictable, relationship-driven.
- **~\$10T** of the wealth transfer flows to charity.

04 THE ENGINE

This is what a **funder corpus + agents** are for. Reach already has a funder corpus under augment-it (dozens of funders, hundreds of documents). Reverse-engineering is the **strategy**; the corpus + agents are the **engine** that makes pattern-matching at scale tractable for a small team.

Sources: Giving USA 2025 (\$592.5B in 2024) • Foundation Source, "From Foundations to DAFs" • Arco Lab, "World's 100 largest philanthropic foundations" • Altrata, World Ultra Wealth Report 2025 • Cerulli, "\$84 Trillion in Wealth Transfers Through 2045" • Instrumentl, "Grant Prospect Research" • Grant Ready KY, "IRS Form 990s for Grant Prospecting" — *draft narrative; figures pending verification.*